

Stuff of Legend

A village in Rajasthan deifies a royal revolutionary whose patriotic deeds inspire people even today



RAO CHANDRASEN
(SITTING, CENTRE)
PRESIDES AT THE
KHARWA FAIR

By Uday Mahurkar

More than 60 years after India shook off the shackles of British rule to gain Independence, stories of heroism from the days of the Raj are alive and well. Though a majority of the princely states sided with the British during the struggle for Independence, a few rulers overtly or covertly supported the outlaws. One of them was Gopalsingh, the ruler of a small principality called Kharwa near Bhilwara in Rajasthan. He funded and actively participated in the revolutionary activities of Rash Bihari Bose, Maharshi Aurobindo Ghosh and Bhagat Singh. Gopalsingh created a nucleus of some leading rulers who were willing to secretly support the movement. Kharwa became a secret centre of the movement in Central India as he supplied arms, ammunition and shelter to the fighters.

Documents in the Rajasthan state archives and with Rao Chandrasen, great grandson of Gopalsingh, prove that he was one of the chief actors in the famous but unsuccessful 1915 coup hatched by revolutionaries led by Bose. The plan failed because secrecy was lost and

Gopalsingh was jailed for five years. The nation today is unaware about the contribution of Gopalsingh who died in 1939. But for the past 70 years a grateful Kharwa remembers him on his birth anniversary in March. A grand celebration led by Chandrasen is held with almost Holi-like fervour where thousands join after garlanding Gopalsingh's statue. There are competitions of the local dance, *ger*. Villagers smear colour on each others' faces, make merry and shop at the fair. Gopalsingh is almost like the presiding deity of the village; he is also remembered as a great ruler who emptied the state treasury in times of famine. When a child is down with fever in Kharwa and seems incurable, the crestfallen mother often prays for recovery at his *samadhi* (cenotaph). Villagers believe such prayers yield instant results. Says Manish Daghdhi, 25, a farmer, "My grandparents told me many heroic stories about Gopalsinghji. Today's rulers should emulate him whether it is on Pakistan's hostile designs or people-friendly governance." Old soldiers fade away, they say, but revolutionaries like Gopalsingh live forever. ■